disruption and distraction. Some of the senior officers even went to the extent of interfering in the conduct of the exercise. Hence, they had to be politely but firmly put in their place. It was conveyed to participating units and formations that all outsiders were to be treated as visitors irrespective of their rank or status. However, it boosted our morale to have the defence minister and the army chief amongst us in May, sharing the heat and dust storms of Rajasthan. The defence minister decided to live with us in the Corps Tactical HQs tucked away in the sand dunes, as did General Padmanabhan, rather than in the circuit house nearby. He was quite at home living for two nights in my caravan based on a 3-ton Shaktiman truck, which I had christened Chetak. He was also happy to move around in my custom-built jeep that was my operations room on wheels. Air Chief Marshal A.Y. Tipnis not only attended the exercise, but also flew a MIG 21 sortie in support of Blueland.

The defence minister was very keen to see the tanks in action, as he had himself served in the cavalry before joining politics. Therefore, it was planned to fly him in a MI 17 helicopter over the exercise area, and make him witness a modern tank battle. Unlike many such high-profile events that are stage-managed and rehearsed, this one was not. I wanted the defence minister and my chief to see the exercise as it was unfolding, the real stuff, warts and all. Before taking off, I briefed the pilots on the map about the axis on which the armoured columns were advancing, and the few prominent landmarks to follow, so that we could fly over the area and see the activities from the air.

Unfortunately, the pilots were new to this area, having flown all the way from Delhi only a day back. The helicopters for the minister and the army chief belonged to the elite VIP Squadron. We seemed to have run out of luck as despite their best efforts, we could not spot any movement of tanks or even the odd blaze of dust in that vast featureless desert that we could see up to the horizon! The pilots kept trying for almost an hour, and eventually gave up. They sought my directions to turn back to base. I went into the cockpit and asked the crew to give it one more go. Sitting in the cockpit on the bench meant for the navigator, I put on the headphones and got